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Léa

June 1943

In the beginning, Léa had struggled to decipher Josef's handwriting. He wrote with an odd slant, and because he was left-handed, the ink frequently smudged as his hand swept over it. But after she became familiar with the curls, twists and lines of his script, as well as the German keyboard, her proficiency and speed increased.

What she liked best was the time that they spent together going over the reports. He checked her transcription and made corrections. She asked him questions on German grammar, which he kindly explained, helping to improve her fluency. And what made it all worthwhile was the extra time he was able to devote to his patients, since he was the only doctor for all three thousand foreign workers assigned to Glashütte by mid-1943.

That morning at the factory, Léa noticed Maria struggled to meet her quota. Her usually efficient assembly of the lenses on the gunsights seemed sluggish. Léa suspected that by the time the lunch hour rolled around, Maria would be behind and she knew from experience that once that happened, it would be nearly impossible to catch up.

"What's wrong?" Léa asked in German.

Either Maria couldn't hear over the clanging of the machines, or she lacked the energy to speak because she didn't answer. The poultice Léa had given her a few months back had visibly reduced the swelling and redness in her eye. And though at the time she'd been grateful, she warned Léa to be careful. "If Lagerführer Klein finds out you've given me medicine, you'll be in trouble."

"She won't find out." Léa had wanted to put her friend at ease. "And it's